YUJUAN GAO

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EMPLOYMENT

The Kohl Centre, Virginia Tech *May 2026 – Present*
Postdoctoral Research Associate

EDUCATION

University of Florida *August 2021 – May 2026*
Food and Resource Economics Department
Ph.D., Applied Economics

Stanford Center on China's Economy and Institutions *August 2018 – August 2019*
Visiting Graduate Research Fellow

Shaanxi Normal University *August 2016 – December 2019*
M.A., Economics

Shanxi University of Finance and Economics *September 2012 – July 2016*
B.S., Statistics

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Stanford Center on China's Economy and Institutions *July 2025 – Present*
Research Assistant

Food and Resource Economics Department, University of Florida *August 2021 – May 2026*
Teaching and Research Assistant

Save the Children, China *July 2020 – January 2021*
Consultant for Yunnan Ludian 0–3 Years Early Childhood Development Project

RESEARCH FIELDS

Primary: Development Economics, Health Economics, Economics of Education
Secondary: Spatial Economics, Causal Inference, Food Nutrition

DISSERTATION RESEARCH

Bridging the Digital Divide: How 3G Internet Coverage Transforms Fertility Decisions in Nigeria, Accepted for Presentation (Poster), ASSA 2026

This paper examines whether mobile internet access influences fertility behavior and women's autonomy in high-fertility settings. I link georeferenced 3G coverage data to 80,247 women from the 2013 and 2018 ***Nigerian Demographic and Health Surveys****, using reconstructed birth histories to form a birth panel spanning 2013–2018, and match these outcomes to local 3G coverage measured over the 2012–2017 rollout period. Exploiting the staggered expansion of mobile broadband infrastructure, I implement* ***heterogeneity-robust difference-in-differences*** *designs. A one-standard deviation increase in 3G coverage reduces the annual birth probability among adolescent women ages 12–20 by 1.3–1.8 percentage points. Event-study estimates confirm parallel pre-trends and show that effects strengthen with exposure duration. Mechanism analyses indicate that fertility reductions operate through delayed cohabitation and postponed first births rather than increased contraceptive adoption. Mobile internet exposure also improves educational attainment and shifts young women from unpaid or family labor into moderate-skill wage employment, consistent with rising opportunity costs of early childbearing.*

SKILLS

R, Stata, Python, SQL, ArcGIS, LaTeX, GitHub, scikit-learn, EconML, Qualtrics

SELECTED PUBLICATIONS

"Who sits next to whom? The role of physical distance in shaping academic achievement in rural China." (with Yu Bai; Yue Ma; Andrew Rule; Scott Rozelle) *China Agricultural Economic Review*, 2026. [click here]

"Do Color-Coded Nutrition Facts Panels Nudge the Use of Nutrition Information on Food Packaging?" (with Xuqi Chen, Lisa House, and Zhifeng Gao) *Food Policy*, 2024. [click here]

"Associations between Urbanization and the Home Language Environment: Evidence from a LENA Study in Rural and Peri-urban China" (with Yue Ma, Scott Rozelle, *et al.*) *Child Development*, 2023. [click here]

"Maternal Health Behaviors during Pregnancy in Rural Northwestern China" (with Yue Ma, Sarah-Eve Dill, *et al.*) *BMC Pregnancy and Childbirth*, 2020. [click here]

"Arrival Order for Positive and Negative Effects of Parental Migration on the Academic Performance of Left-behind Children in Rural China" (with Yu Bai) *Studies in Labor Economics* (in Chinese), 2018.

WORKING PAPERS

Unintended Consequences of Best Intentions: Examining Spillover Effects in Targeted Supplementary Education Interventions (with Conner Mullally and Yue Ma), Under Review

*This study investigates **spillover effects** from targeted **educational interventions** in resource constrained settings. Through a **cluster-randomized controlled trial** across 130 rural Chinese primary schools, I assigned boarding students to computer-assisted learning (CAL), traditional workbook exercises, or control conditions, then measured effects on over 6,400 untreated non-boarding classmates. Workbook interventions generated significant negative spillovers, reducing non-boarding students' math performance by 0.087 standard deviations, with effects intensifying among students who frequently interacted with treated peers and in classrooms with higher treatment density. In contrast, CAL programs implemented outside regular classrooms produced no spillover effects. Mechanism analysis reveals that workbook exposure undermines untreated students' instrumental motivation—their belief that mathematical effort will improve future opportunities—while leaving classroom competition and teacher attention patterns unchanged.*

Using Text Messages to Improve Parenting Knowledge and Early Childhood Development in Rural China (with Yue Ma and Susanna Loeb), Under Review

*This study evaluates whether low-cost **"Tips-by-Text" interventions** can improve **early childhood outcomes** in under-resourced rural Chinese communities. Drawing on a **randomized controlled trial** with caregivers of children ages 0–3, the program delivered weekly text messages offering actionable guidance on play, language stimulation, and nutrition. The intervention significantly increased caregiver engagement, strengthened home learning environments, and improved children's language and cognitive development. Impacts were largest among caregivers facing higher parenting barriers. The results demonstrate that simple, scalable mobile messaging can effectively support early childhood development where access to formal services is limited.*

WORK IN PROGRESS

Maternal Migration and Early Child Development in Rural China
Determination of Labor Demand and Wage, Evidence from 500 Million Job Posts in China

POLICY AND OUTREACH WRITINGS

Bai, Yu and **Yujuan Gao** (2021). "Save the Children Yunnan Ludian 0–3 Years Early Childhood Development Project (2019–2020) Evaluation Report."

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

AEB 3103 - Principles of Food & Resource Economics	Teaching Assistant for 49 students	*2025*
AEB3341 - Selling Strategically	Teaching Assistant for 65 students	*2024*
AEB3133 - Principles of Agribusiness Management	Teaching Assistant for 89 students	*2023*
IDS 2935-22961 - How Do We End Poverty?	Guest Lecture	*2023*
AEB3671 - Comparative World Agriculture	Teaching Assistant for 69 students	*2023*
AEB4283 - International Development Policy	Teaching Assistant for 77 students	*2022*
AEB4673 - International Agricultural Trade	Teaching Assistant for 9 students	*2022*

AWARDS AND SCHOLARSHIPS

J. R. Greenman Memorial Scholarship from CALS, University of Florida	*2022, 2024*
Young Scholar Excellent Paper Award, China Education Finance Research Association	*2023*
Best Paper Awards, Agricultural & Applied Economics Association Annual Conference	*2020*

CONFERENCES AND SEMINAR PRESENTATIONS

2026: ASSA
2025: ASSA; AAEA; Advances with Field Experiments (AFE); NABE Tech Economics Conference
2024: Global GLO-JOPE Conference (Job Market Session); APPAM Fall Conference; CES North America Annual Conference; PacDev at Stanford; SSC Young Researcher Workshop at Stanford; AAEA
2023: NEUDC at Harvard; AAEA Annual Conference
2022: WEAI 97th Annual Meeting
2020: AAEA Annual Conference

PROFESSIONAL ACTIVITIES

Referee: BMC Public Health; PLOS One; China Economic Review
Certification: Preparing Future Faculty Program, Center for Teaching Excellence, University of Florida (Fall 2024)
Service: Mentor, 2025 Summer AEA Mentoring Program